

art The Individualist

KOLKATA Gobardhan Ash did an entire series on children and his works had a child-like simplicity about them, but the issues addressed by the late Bengal School artist were serious and moved him deeply. In the year of his birth centenary, Aakriti Art Gallery has decided to pay a fitting tribute in the form of an exhibition of a huge body of his work. Sourced from Ash's family, the works include his early watercolours from the 1930s, as well as what was perhaps his last painting in 1996, the year Ash, at the age of 89, breathed his last.

A student of the Government College of Art in Kolkata, Ash never completed his studies. A recluse by nature right from his early days, Ash was discovered in 1945 by the Progressive Writers' Association, which displayed a series of his works, done chiefly in watercolour and ink during the 1943 famine. Post famine, Ash took to gouache as a medium and continued with it through the 1950s. In the 1960s, he switched to oil, painting a series on children in different moods.

The paintings clearly mark his individuality. Immune to the art trends of his time, he went back to his landscapes in the 1970s, depicting tired and toiling people to reflect the socio-economic reality of rural India.

At the same time, he painted a parallel set of works that dealt with intimate figures up close and personal. "The two sets painted simultaneously reflected the artist's view of life," says art critic Sovon Som, explaining that they show "the two facets of human existence: man in his collective struggle for survival against the grim realities of the prevailing socio-economic conditions, and man, the individual in his solitary moments, when he is uniquely himself."

When he was alive, numerous exhibitions were held of Ash's works, mostly thanks to initiatives by others. Two posthumous exhibitions were held in the last decade: a solo at the Gaja Art Gallery in Singapore in 1997 and another at Delhi's Habitat Centre in 2000. Aakriti's show not only comes at the right time, it also serves the purpose of reviewing the artist's life through his works. At Aakriti, from July 22 to August 5. **by Swagata Sen**

NO CHILD'S PLAY: Ash painted a whole series on children



art exhibition Creative Espionage

MUMBAI It's sure to have everyone wanting to spy out what's happening. If you're wondering what we're talking about, Bose Krishnamachari's exhibition, titled 'Spy', should give you some answers. Through specimens of espionage, the curator explores man's innate curiosity about everything around him. The collection includes works by artists C.K. Rajan, Dia Mehta, Prasad Raghavan and Simrin Mehra Agarwal, who, through a sort of subterfuge, divulge clues to mysteries in the form of art. "Man is curious about the lives of others. It is a natural act, sometimes intended to protect himself, sometimes to survive, sometimes to entertain," explains Krishnamachari. That the subject of art, the holder of the secret, is not always aware of being spied on, adds to the thrill. A mystery that is both revealed and concealed, the exhibition will be on at The Guild Art Gallery from July 30 to August 5. **by Swati Mathur**

CLASSIC MYSTERY: The works of art arouse curiosity



music festival Monsoon Magic

DELHI "With the first showers, your voice tunes to monsoon ragas," says vocalist Pandit Chhannulal Mishra. There is none who does not feel the creative energy of the monsoon. Banyan Tree Events presents Barkha Ritu, Rains and Ragas- 2007, featuring Pandit Shivkumar Sharma on the santoor on July 27 at



Pandit Chhannulal Mishra

Kamani Auditorium. The festival travels to Bangalore the next day, with vocalist Ustad Rashid Khan and Pandit Hariprasad Chaurasia on the flute. At Chowdiah Auditorium.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit